

Figure 5. South India in 1565[8]

What Foreign Travellers Saw in Vijayanagar

Vijayanagar is ‘the best provided city in the world’, wrote one traveller. It is of ‘enormous magnitude and population’, wrote another. Our historical knowledge of Vijayanagar comes from a range of sources, such as inscriptions on stone and copper plates, archaeology, literary works, temple land grants and trade records. A Persian chronicler in the employ of Deccan sultans, Muhammad Kasim Firishta, has left many details though he wrote a generation after the sacking of Vijayanagar, and his accounts often seem dubious and lurid, especially of war.[10] At times, he seems partial to the perspective of his patrons and exaggerates their side’s military exploits. Finally, a good chunk of what we know about Vijayanagar comes from the eyewitness accounts of foreign travellers.

Among the travellers whose writings on Vijayanagar have survived are Niccolo de Conti, a Venetian merchant (1420); Abdur Razzaq Samarqandi, a Persian scholar-envoy (1443); Duarte Barbosa, a Portuguese officer (c. 1515); and Domingo Paes (c. 1520) and Fernao Nuniz (1535–37), Portuguese merchant-adventurers. While much of what they describe is real and useful, some of them lacked adequate language skills or cultural context to know what they were looking at. They moreover wrote for audiences back home, often relied on hearsay rather than personal observation and held various cultural biases towards the ‘heathens’ and ‘idolaters’ of the subcontinent. They were more drawn to things they found